Cookin' Up the Competition

By Ira Brodsky and Barbara Lhota

Grace and Stephanie are successful career women and mothers who often feel the need to compete with each other. Grace is jealous of Stephanie's culinary talents and Stephanie envies Grace's skill at home decorating. Today, they find out that perhaps their jealousies are unjustified.

INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS 1: *It's been a longstanding view that women are fiercely competitive with each other.*
ACTRESS 2: *Where does this need to compete come from? The most commonly held belief is that it comes from feelings of insecurity.*
ACTRESS 1: *When the media is hell bent on portraying the "ideal" female body as model thin:*
ACTRESS 2: *5 foot 8 and 115 pounds (Stands on tiptoes and sucks in, then exhales) Yeah, right!*
ACTRESS 1: *It's easy to feel threatened by the beauty and talent of other women.*
ACTRESS 2: *According to Emily Gordon, the author of the book, Super You: Release Your Inner Superhero, "We look at other women and see a version of ourselves that is better, prettier, smarter, something more."*
ACTRESS 1: *We are in constant competition with ourselves! And it has to stop!*
ACTRESS 2: *Today, we're blowing the doors off this crazy one-upsman-ship with . . .*
TOGETHER: *Cookin' Up the Competition by Ira Brodsky and Barbara Lhota*

(Grace reaches for a box of cake mix and begins reading the directions.)

STEPHANIE: Why do you have these eggs on the radiator?

GRACE: It calls for them to be room temperature.

STEPHANIE: Room temperature, yes, not roasting toxic salmonella eggs.

GRACE: Well, I don't know. That's why I asked you to come over here and advise.

STEPHANIE: Grace, you are not a cook. You will never be a cook. Stop cooking. Look what happened last time.

GRACE: A little mishap. Pfff. It all worked out.

STEPHANIE: Yeah, three fire trucks and several smoke inhalations later.

GRACE: You exaggerate. Nothing caught fire.

STEPHANIE: Except your cat.

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GRACE: I forgot about that. But she rolled herself out immediately, and now she's fine. *(Beat)* I'm not talking to you. I'm putting away the eggs. *(Beat)* So did you see the little thing I threw up in the front foyer?

STEPHANIE: The gorgeous, embroidered wall hanging? How could I miss it? I suppose you made it yourself.

GRACE: Well ... Don't go on and on about it. You just embarrass me. So you liked it?

STEPHANIE: Yes, it's gorgeous and not little. So let's bag the baking-the-cake thing. We all have our skills. Baking's not yours.

GRACE: Look, just this once. I want to bake Mike a birthday cake from scratch.

STEPHANIE: I hate to break this, Grace, but a Betty Crocker cake is not exactly from scratch.

GRACE: Look, I break an egg. I put it in the oven. For me, that's baking.

STEPHANIE: Tell you what. We go to a nice bakery. We mess up the frosting so it's not perfect and everyone will think we-***you***-made it from scratch. It'll be real nice.

GRACE: That doesn't sound nice. In fact, it sounds downright dishonest.

STEPHANIE: Well, it's the thought that counts anyway!

GRACE: Thought-schmought. I want to make a big, honkin' homemade cake with fresh fruit something and to-die-for layers, a whipped icing-oozing thing! The sort of masterpiece that you're always making for us. That fresh vegetable lasagna you made last time we visited? Mike wrote an original song singing its praises. He probably would have given our first-born child for an extra slice.

STEPHANIE: You only have the one.

GRACE: I know. You want to compete on that too?

STEPHANIE: I'm not competing! Who said I'm competing?

GRACE: O,h come on. Look at the evidence. First you have a second child- Then you buy a bigger house

STEPHANIE: Well, we had a smaller house than you to begin with.

GRACE: See?! Then while holding down an impressive job, you finish your law degree.

STEPHANIE: Well, you're writing your dissertation. You're almost finished.

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GRACE: Yeah, and I've been almost finished since like, like 1999. And then you make an incredible lasagna that turns my husband into Rodgers and Hammerstein.

STEPHANIE: Look, I wouldn't be forced to impress you with my baking if I wasn't so moved by the way you decorate every charmed room in your house. You know, even Drew comments. He asked me why our house can't look that good.

GRACE: Oh come on!

STEPHANIE: I'm serious, making all those slipcovers, and pillows, and your color sense. And then the embroidering! It's all so unbelievably talented that the least I could do is throw together flour and eggs into something incredible. *(Awkward silence)*

GRACE: *(taking a picture off the fridge)* You should see my little Lincoln! His teacher says he's such a good artist he'll probably be an architect. He got the class award in art.

STEPHANIE: Umm. That's wonderful. Chrissy is doing well too. She's just a crackerjack with words. The teacher said she's gifted. She's starting to read.

GRACE: At her age? That's advanced.

STEPHANIE: Isn't Lincoln?

GRACE: Well, sometimes they say it's better to develop the spatial brain first. A lot of times, it gives kids a good grounding. They become better in math.

STEPHANIE: Yes, that's true, but then there's communication. Reading. Verbal abilities. Chrissy's a great communicator. She has three good friends already, and even a boyfriend. How's Lincoln on that score?

GRACE: Well, he has friends. He has lots of friends. *(More quietly)* Some of them are imaginary, but I think that's healthy.

STEPHANIE: Well, children all develop at their own pace. For instance, it took Lincoln several months longer to turn over.

GRACE: I knew it! I knew you were going to go there!

STEPHANIE: What's the matter? That's not a *bad* thing.

GRACE: So he took a month longer to turn over! He was examining the carpet fibers. He could be an engineer someday.

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STEPHANIE: Sure, or a carpet ... inspector.

GRACE: He's probably more focused. Not flipping every which way. Flitting about and chatting it up with every preschool boy he meets.

STEPHANIE: You make her sound like a bubble-headed flirt.

GRACE: Well, you make him sound like a social *reject*!

STEPHANIE: Look, I don't need this! I just came over to help.

GRACE: Help?! All you do is make me feel bad about myself! *(Mimicing)* Drew got a promotion. Chrissy's a genius. I bake Martha Stewart cakes and you never will!

STEPHANIE: I never said you never will! *(Grace gives her a look)* OK, maybe I did say that, but I didn't mean it.

GRACE: You always have to one up me.

STEPHANIE: That's ridiculous! That's what you do to me.

GRACE: So Chrissy's a social whiz kid! And my Lincoln'll end up a carpet cleaner!

STEPHANIE: Well, at least your son doesn't eat paste and stuff it up her friend's nose.

GRACE: What? Chrissy? Well-adjusted, social-whiz Chrissy?

STEPHANIE: Yes! Well-adjusted when she's not stuffing paste up her friend's nose and dining on it. I could have died. Her "guide" teacher asked me what I was feeding *her-What is her sugar quotient?* I told her I gave her apples, and apple sauce occasionally, but only if I processed fresh apples in our own food processor-most of the time.

GRACE: Oh, that was a good answer. That'll keep 'em off you.

STEPHANIE: Yeah, except she locked onto "most of the time." She finally got it out of me that I occasionally give her storebought. Jeez. I guess I'm a bad mother.

GRACE: Me too, because sometimes I give him *(Whispers)* McDonald's. We're great moms, loving and caring. And you especially! With all that cooking you do! Chrissy's gonna grow up knowing her mom really cares.

STEPHANIE: Well, I do, of course, care. A lot. But I don't really cook very much.

GRACE: What?!

STEPHANIE: Look, I can't be bothered with it all. I just buy stuff like from the international food

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store, heat it up, and throw it on the plates with a sprig of parsley.

GRACE: You're kidding? But you ... But we ... But Mike . . . So you can't cook?!

STEPHANIE: I'm worse than you.

GRACE: No-And the lasagna?

STEPHANIE: Mario's Frozen Italian Dinners. Straight from Farmer Jack's.

GRACE: Oh my God!

STEPHANIE: Yes. I'm sorry. I can't live the lie anymore. I just wanted you to think I could do something domestic right since you sew so incredibly well.

GRACE: Steph? I have something to admit to you. I don't sew.

STEPHANIE: At all?! *(Grace shakes her head no)* But what about all those pillows and the wall hanging and those colors you put to-

GRACE: My decorator and my mother.

STEPHANIE: No! (beat) God, I feel better about myself.

GRACE: Me too!

STEPHANIE: So what else have you been lying about?

GRACE: I don't know. Well, my workout schedule.

STEPHANIE: Oh my God! Me too. So it's not five times a week?

GRACE: Once if I'm lucky. And you? How's the running?

STEPHANIE: Fine, but mostly to the fridge. And I didn't actually lose anything on Weight Watchers either.

GRACE: I gained!

STEPHANIE: Me too! And what about the-? *(Refers to her breasts)* Did you have a little enhancement?

GRACE: Gel-filled bras.

STEPHANIE: Are you kidding? I can't afford the designer stuff.

GRACE: Designer? Where do you think I shop?

STEPHANIE: I don't know ... Target?

GRACE: Bull's-eye!

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STEPHANIE: Oh my God! Me too! By the way, you know how I finished with my law degree? I don't even want to be a lawyer anymore.

GRACE: Oh my God, Stephanie, but the loans on that.

STEPHANIE: I know.

GRACE: Oh, honey, I'm so sorry ... and I'm so happy ... I mean, I'm kind of relieved ...

STEPHANIE: Knock it off. I know what you mean. I have an idea. Let's go to the bakery and find the most gorgeous cake we can.

GRACE: And we'll tell Mike I made it!

STEPHANIE: He'll think I'm the greatest teacher in the world!

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